

WEB ACCESSIBILITY · WCAG 2.2 LEVEL AA

The WCAG 2.2 AA Checklist, *in plain English*

All 55 Level A and AA success criteria, each in one plain sentence — what to check, why it matters, and how to test it. Organised by the four POUR principles.



How to use this checklist

This is a working checklist for reaching **WCAG 2.2 Level AA** — the conformance level required by the European Accessibility Act (via EN 301 549), the US DOJ's ADA Title II rule and Section 508. AA conformance means meeting every Level A *and* Level AA success criterion, so all 55 are listed here.

Work principle by principle. Tick an item only when it holds true on every page template, not just the homepage. Many criteria can be checked by hand in minutes; a few need assistive-technology testing. The last chapter shows how to test and what automated tools can — and can't — find.

This is guidance to help you understand WCAG 2.2 AA, not legal advice. Confirm against the official W3C text and a qualified adviser for decisions specific to your organisation. © 2026 EAA Navigator.
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00

How WCAG works

Principles, levels and the 55 criteria you need for AA

The standard behind the law *in brief*

The Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) are the international benchmark for digital accessibility, published by the W3C. The current version is **WCAG 2.2** (a W3C Recommendation since October 2023). Nearly every accessibility law points to it: the EU's EN 301 549 (the harmonised standard behind the European Accessibility Act) uses WCAG, the DOJ's ADA Title II rule adopts WCAG 2.1 AA, and Section 508 references WCAG 2.0 AA.

THE FOUR PRINCIPLES — POUR

Every success criterion sits under one of four principles. Content must be **Perceivable** (people can sense it), **Operable** (people can use the controls), **Understandable** (it's clear and predictable) and **Robust** (it works with assistive technologies).

Three levels: A, AA, AAA

WCAG has three conformance levels. **Level A** is the minimum, **Level AA** is the standard target that the law expects, and **Level AAA** is the highest and isn't expected across a whole site. Reaching AA means satisfying every Level A criterion as well — so this checklist covers both.

50

criteria in WCAG 2.1 AA

55

criteria in WCAG 2.2 AA (this checklist)

+5

net new at AA: 6 added, 1 removed

WCAG 2.2 added nine success criteria across all levels and removed one (4.1.1 Parsing, now obsolete), a net increase of five at each level. The new criteria that matter for AA are **2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured**, **2.5.7 Dragging Movements**, **2.5.8 Target Size (Minimum)** and **3.3.8 Accessible Authentication**. (Focus Appearance is AAA, not AA — a common mix-up.) WCAG 3.0 is still an early draft and is *not* a compliance target.

REALITY CHECK

Automated tools find a fraction of this

Automated checkers and accessibility “overlays” can only detect roughly **30–40%** of WCAG issues. The rest — keyboard operability, focus order, sensible reading order, meaningful alt text, screen-reader semantics — need a person. Treat this checklist as the human layer that automation can't replace.



Accessibility is a team effort — design, engineering and content each own part of the checklist.

01

Perceivable

Can everyone perceive the content, whatever sense they use?

Perceivable 20 criteria

Information and interface components must be presentable in ways people can perceive — with their eyes, their ears, or through assistive technology. This is where most real-world failures live: low-contrast text and missing alt text are the two most common problems on the web.

- ☐ **1.1.1 Non-text Content** Level A
Every meaningful image, icon, chart and control has a text alternative; purely decorative images are marked so assistive tech skips them.
- ☐ **1.2.1 Audio-only and Video-only (Prerecorded)** Level A
Pre-recorded audio-only has a transcript; pre-recorded video-only has a transcript or audio description.
- ☐ **1.2.2 Captions (Prerecorded)** Level A
All pre-recorded video that has sound carries synchronised captions.
- ☐ **1.2.3 Audio Description or Media Alternative (Prerecorded)** Level A
Pre-recorded video offers either audio description or a full text alternative of the visual content.
- ☐ **1.2.4 Captions (Live)** Level AA
Live video with audio (webinars, streams) has real-time captions.
- ☐ **1.2.5 Audio Description (Prerecorded)** Level AA
Pre-recorded video includes audio description of the important visual detail.
- ☐ **1.3.1 Info and Relationships** Level A
Structure — headings, lists, tables, form labels — is coded in the markup, not conveyed by styling alone.
- ☐ **1.3.2 Meaningful Sequence** Level A
The reading and navigation order in the code still makes sense when the CSS is removed.
- ☐ **1.3.3 Sensory Characteristics** Level A
Instructions don't rely on shape, size or position alone (avoid "click the round button on the right").
- ☐ **1.3.4 Orientation** Level AA
Content works in both portrait and landscape; orientation isn't locked unless essential.
- ☐ **1.3.5 Identify Input Purpose** Level AA
Common fields such as name and email use the right autocomplete value so they can be filled automatically.
- ☐ **1.4.1 Use of Color** Level A
Colour is never the only way meaning is conveyed — errors, links and states also use text, shape or an icon.
- ☐ **1.4.2 Audio Control** Level A
Audio that plays automatically for more than three seconds can be paused, stopped or muted.
- ☐ **1.4.3 Contrast (Minimum)** Level AA
Text has a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1 against its background (3:1 for large text $\geq 24\text{px}$, or $\geq 18.66\text{px}$ bold).
- ☐ **1.4.4 Resize Text** Level AA
Text can be zoomed to 200% without loss of content or function.
- ☐ **1.4.5 Images of Text** Level AA
Real text is used instead of pictures of text, except for logos.
- ☐ **1.4.10 Reflow** Level AA
Content reflows to a single column at 320 CSS pixels wide with no horizontal scrolling.
- ☐ **1.4.11 Non-text Contrast** Level AA
Interface components and meaningful graphics have at least 3:1 contrast against what's next to them.
- ☐ **1.4.12 Text Spacing** Level AA
Nothing is lost or cut off when users increase line height and letter, word and paragraph spacing.



1.4.13 Content on Hover or Focus Level AA

Tooltips and pop-ups can be dismissed, hovered over, and stay visible until dismissed.

02

Operable

Can everyone operate the interface — keyboard, touch or mouse?

Operable 20 criteria

Every control and piece of navigation must be usable, regardless of input device. The single most important test here is simple: unplug your mouse and try to do everything with the keyboard alone.

- ☐ **2.1.1 Keyboard** Level A
Everything that works with a mouse also works with a keyboard alone.
- ☐ **2.1.2 No Keyboard Trap** Level A
Keyboard focus can always move away from any component; nothing traps it.
- ☐ **2.1.4 Character Key Shortcuts** Level A
Single-character shortcuts can be turned off, remapped, or only fire on focus.
- ☐ **2.2.1 Timing Adjustable** Level A
Time limits can be turned off, adjusted, or extended before they expire.
- ☐ **2.2.2 Pause, Stop, Hide** Level A
Moving, blinking, scrolling or auto-updating content can be paused, stopped or hidden.
- ☐ **2.3.1 Three Flashes or Below Threshold** Level A
Nothing flashes more than three times in any one second.
- ☐ **2.4.1 Bypass Blocks** Level A
A skip link or proper landmarks let users jump past repeated navigation.
- ☐ **2.4.2 Page Titled** Level A
Every page has a unique, descriptive title element.
- ☐ **2.4.3 Focus Order** Level A
Focus moves through the page in an order that preserves meaning and operability.
- ☐ **2.4.4 Link Purpose (In Context)** Level A
Each link's purpose is clear from its text, or from its immediate context.
- ☐ **2.4.5 Multiple Ways** Level AA
There's more than one way to reach a page — a menu, a search, a sitemap.
- ☐ **2.4.6 Headings and Labels** Level AA
Headings and form labels accurately describe the content or control they introduce.
- ☐ **2.4.7 Focus Visible** Level AA
The keyboard focus indicator is always clearly visible.
- ☐ **2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured (Minimum)** Level AA
The element with focus isn't entirely hidden behind sticky headers, footers or cookie bars. (New in 2.2)
- ☐ **2.5.1 Pointer Gestures** Level A
Multi-finger or path-based gestures have a simple single-pointer alternative.
- ☐ **2.5.2 Pointer Cancellation** Level A
Actions complete on release, not press, so a mis-tap can be aborted.
- ☐ **2.5.3 Label in Name** Level A
A control's visible label is contained in its accessible name (so voice control works).
- ☐ **2.5.4 Motion Actuation** Level A
Anything triggered by shaking or tilting the device can also be done with normal controls.
- ☐ **2.5.7 Dragging Movements** Level AA
Any drag action has a simple click or tap alternative. (New in 2.2)
- ☐ **2.5.8 Target Size (Minimum)** Level AA
Pointer targets are at least 24x24 CSS pixels, or have enough spacing around them. (New in 2.2)

03

Understandable

Is the content clear, and does the interface behave predictably?

Understandable 13 criteria

Content and operation must be clear and predictable. Forms are the hot spot: clear labels, helpful errors, and no surprises when a field changes.

- ☐ **3.1.1 Language of Page** Level A
The page's default language is set with a lang attribute on the html element.
- ☐ **3.1.2 Language of Parts** Level AA
Passages in a different language are marked up with their own lang attribute.
- ☐ **3.2.1 On Focus** Level A
Moving focus to a component doesn't trigger an unexpected change of context.
- ☐ **3.2.2 On Input** Level A
Changing a field's value doesn't automatically submit the form or jump the user somewhere.
- ☐ **3.2.3 Consistent Navigation** Level AA
Navigation that repeats across pages appears in the same relative order each time.
- ☐ **3.2.4 Consistent Identification** Level AA
Components with the same function are labelled and named consistently across the site.
- ☐ **3.2.6 Consistent Help** Level A
Help options — contact details, chat, a help link — appear in the same place across pages. (New in 2.2)
- ☐ **3.3.1 Error Identification** Level A
Input errors are described to the user in text, not by colour alone.
- ☐ **3.3.2 Labels or Instructions** Level A
Form fields have visible labels and any instructions needed to complete them.
- ☐ **3.3.3 Error Suggestion** Level AA
When an error is detected and a fix is known, the correction is suggested.
- ☐ **3.3.4 Error Prevention (Legal, Financial, Data)** Level AA
Important submissions can be reviewed, corrected, confirmed or reversed before they're final.
- ☐ **3.3.7 Redundant Entry** Level A
Information already entered in a process is auto-populated or selectable, not re-typed from memory. (New in 2.2)
- ☐ **3.3.8 Accessible Authentication (Minimum)** Level AA
Logging in doesn't depend on a cognitive test like solving a puzzle or transcribing a code. (New in 2.2)

04

Robust

Does it work with browsers and assistive technologies, now and later?

Robust 2 criteria

Content must be robust enough to be interpreted reliably by browsers and assistive technologies. WCAG 2.2 removed the old 4.1.1 Parsing criterion as obsolete, leaving two criteria at A and AA — but they carry a lot of weight for screen-reader users.

- ☐ **4.1.2 Name, Role, Value** Level A
Every interactive component exposes its name, role and current state to assistive tech — the heart of correct ARIA on custom widgets.
- ☐ **4.1.3 Status Messages** Level AA
Status messages ("added to cart", "3 results", "saved") are announced by assistive tech without moving focus.

NOTE ON 4.1.1 PARSING

If you're coming from WCAG 2.0 or 2.1, note that **4.1.1 Parsing** was removed in WCAG 2.2. You no longer test for it — modern browsers handle the markup quirks it covered. Well-formed HTML still matters for everything else, though.

05

Test it & what's next

How to test each layer, and where automated tools stop

From checklist to confidence *a testing routine*

A reliable accessibility check combines automated scanning with human testing. Run them in this order and you'll catch far more than a tool alone.

1 Run an automated scan

Use a tool like axe DevTools, WAVE or Lighthouse on each page template. It flags the machine-detectable issues fast — missing alt text, missing labels, low contrast, missing lang.

2 Test with the keyboard

Put the mouse away. Tab through every page: can you reach and operate everything, is the focus indicator always visible, is the order logical, can you escape every component?

3 Test with a screen reader

Try VoiceOver (Mac/iOS) or NVDA (Windows). Are images described, are headings and landmarks meaningful, are form errors and status messages announced?

4 Check zoom and reflow

Zoom to 200% and 400%, and narrow to 320px. Does content reflow to one column with no clipping or horizontal scroll?

5 Document and prioritise

Record each failure against its success criterion and fix the blocking issues first. Re-test after fixing — and watch for regressions on your next release.

HANDS-ON · 30 MINUTES

Pick your single most important page template — usually the homepage or a key product or checkout page. Work down the Perceivable and Operable lists in this guide against it. Even this short pass almost always surfaces a contrast failure, a missing label or a keyboard trap you can fix this week.

PROMPT TO BRIEF A DEVELOPER

Review this page template against WCAG 2.2 Level AA. For each issue, give me: the success criterion number and name, the specific element, why it fails, and a concrete code fix. Group issues by severity (blocking, serious, minor). Page/template: **[paste URL or component]**.

What automated tools — and overlays — can't do

It's worth repeating: automated checkers catch only about 30-40% of WCAG criteria, and accessibility "overlay" widgets don't change that — they can't make a site conformant, and sites using them are still sued. The Overlay Fact Sheet, signed by 1,000+ accessibility professionals, is clear on this. The remaining majority of WCAG — and the parts that most affect real users — need human and assistive-technology testing.

WHEN YOU NEED CERTAINTY

A manual audit covers the other 60-70%

If you face an EAA, ADA or procurement deadline, an automated scan isn't enough on its own. A manual audit tests every template with a keyboard and a screen reader, maps each finding to its WCAG criterion, and gives you a prioritised fix list you can hand to developers — and, if you sell into procurement, a VPAT/ACR. That's the difference between "we ran a scanner" and "we can show our work."

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Principles, levels, the 55 criteria

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Alt text, contrast, captions, reflow

02 Operable

Keyboard, focus, targets, gestures

03 Understandable

Language, forms, errors, consistency

04 Robust

Name/Role/Value, status messages

05 Test it & what's next

A testing routine + an audit

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